

Narrative Coaching

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INTRODUCTION

Narrative coaching works with coachees at three primary levels: (1) drawing on narrative psychology to understand and connect to the *narrator*; (2) drawing on narrative structure to understand and elicit the material in the *narrated stories*; and (3) drawing on narrative practices to understand and harvest the dynamics of the *narrative field*. The goal is to help coachees to forge new connections between their stories, their identity, and their behaviours in order to generate and embody new options in these three domains. This approach is instinctual given the ancient and cognitive disposition for stories and it is timely given the need for a deeper, more complex understanding of change. Overall, narrative coaching entails a mindful, experiential, and holistic approach to helping coachees shift their stories about themselves, about others, and about life itself in order to create new results.

A brief backstory

In her marvellous history of the narrative turn in the social sciences, Czarniawska (2004) provides an overview of the three main fields that fed into narrative analysis and studies: literary theory, humanities, and psychology. The literary study of narratives focused on an analysis of texts. For example Burke (1969) put forth his Pentad as the central elements in a narrative: 'what was done (*act*), when and where it was done (*scene*), who did it (*agent*), how he did it (*agency*), and why (*purpose*)'. Bruner's (2002) use of *coda*, the meaning and implications of stories, can be seen as a sixth element. With the rise of literary hermeneutics came an interest

in the analysis of interactions of the text and the reader and the subsequent attention to power and discourse.

With the movement into the humanities (e.g. political science, sociology and anthropology), a broader understanding of stories emerged as central to the very fabric of individual and collective life and a frame for a contextual understanding of action. For example phenomenologists such as Berger and Luckmann (1966) and anthropologists such as Geertz (1978) provide important insights into the processes by which we narrate our socially constructed experience. As part of this process, individual stories are viewed within larger cultural narrative frames and forces. Of particular importance for narrative coaching in this regard is Campbell's (1973) work on the heroic journey, van Gennep's (1960) work on rites of passage, and Turner's (1969) work to extend this model into broader cultural life. They provide a theoretical and sociohistorical frame for understanding and guiding change with coachees.

William James was a seminal figure in bringing narrative frames to psychology. James (1927) made the distinction between the *I* (the subject) and the *Me* (the object) – a distinction carried forward as the *self-as-knower* and the *self-as-known* (Hermans, 2004) and the *author* and the *actor* (Mancuso & Sarbin, 1983). This dialectic reflects the ongoing tensions for people in negotiating their narrative identity over time – moving between presenting identities that are socially acceptable and functional and embodying identities that are authentic and consistent with how they see themselves. Coaches would do well to more fully engage the broader humanities as a way to better understand the relational and social nature of both identity and behaviour as they work with their coachees. Adding these systemic elements to coaching yields more sustainable change for clients.

Much of this work was brought together by narrative therapy founders Michael White and David Epston (White, 1988; White & Epston, 1990) who advocated for the deconstruction of dominant narratives, the externalization of problems, and the valuation of 'unique outcomes' or 'exceptions' (Hewson, 1991) in a person's life as contradictions to internalized dominant narratives. Taking this work into coaching, coaches can help coachees to explore alternative territories and possibilities in and for their life by stepping outside their conflation of self with story and external narrative with internal experience. This is useful for coachees because, as Schank (1990) noted, we often see our lives in terms of 'pre-established, well-known stories that can obscure the ways in which our actual situation differs from the standard story' (Schank, 1990: 147).

ASSUMPTIONS OF A NARRATIVE APPROACH

The stories that people tell about their lives are of considerable importance in coaching. The primary assumption here is that there is an intimate connection between the ways in which people see themselves, the ways they narrate their daily life, and the ways in which they behave. Stories are the perfect avenue for exploring these connections because the images they bring to the surface provide material that is indicative of opportunities for inner development and a resource for changing external behaviour. For example in talking with a client about her plan to

move, I asked her to visualize who would be living in the house with her. While exploring this image with her through drawing out related stories, she soon recognizes that the 'house' is also a metaphor and an opening for bigger choices about how she wants to live.

This narrative approach presumes that coachees are continually clarifying, claiming and convincing others of their identity through *positioning* (Davies & Harré, 1990) themselves in both their internal constructions and their external interactions. Narrative coaching helps coachees to recognize their common nature and implications of their patterns as seen in their stories and to enhance their positional repertoire (Hermans, 2004) in order to increase the options that are available to them. However, in order for new stories or new relations between stories to take hold in a coachee's life, they must build on elements of familiar stories in order to 'scaffold' their ascendance (Drake, 2008; Gergen & Gergen, 2006).

In relation to narrative structure the dynamics of conflict are key in helping coachees sort out their positional preferences (Drake, 2008). Nothing moves forward in a story except through conflict and, in fact, the conflict is the axis on which the story turns and the cauldron for its resolution. In narrative coaching, the purpose is not to 'resolve' conflicts but rather to increase coachees' capacity to engage with stronger interpersonal and transpersonal forces and transcend them at a higher level. In narrative coaching, the goal is to help coachees move into the heart of their conflicts to discern what they truly want and how to harness the energies there to achieve it. This is important because a person's true character is revealed in the choices they make under pressure (McKee, 1997) and is what propels them toward a resolution.

ESSENTIAL PROCESSES AND DYNAMICS

Narrative coaching presumes that: (1) identity is situated; (2) growth is liminal; (3) discourse is powerful; and (4) *re-storying* is possible. Together, they represent a novel approach to coaching that moves beyond modernist assumptions, linear development models, extroverted goal orientation, and lingering biases toward behaviourism. The focus shifts from the coach and coaching methodologies to the coaching relationship and the stories constituted there.

Identity is situated

Rather than analysing the past or planning for the future, narrative coaching focuses largely on the dynamics in the present as coachees share their stories. As such, there is a bias for working with what IS in contrast to a tendency in coaching to move quickly to what COULD BE. In part, this is about honouring the fact that coachees use their stories to define, develop, and deploy connections between their 'situated selves' (Ochs & Capps, 1996) as part of an ongoing dialectic between themselves and their environments. These stories, and the identities and behaviours associated with them, need to be witnessed and respected before they can be changed. The role of the coach then is to invite coachees to stand fully in the truth of their experience as the first step in their developmental journey.

Coachees' stories are powerful resources in coaching because they make visible their otherwise invisible identity processes, their 'theory of events' (Foucault, 1965), and thereby shed light on their dance between narrative, identity, and performance (Eakin, 1999; Mishler, 1999). This can be seen in the coachee who gained important new insights into his level of stress through exploring his stories about routinely helping others – and fears of what happens when you don't – (narrative), his familial identity as the hyper-responsible oldest son (identity), and his tendencies to micromanage others at work (performance). A narrative approach to coaching can begin with any of the three dimensions to get at the core issues and to identify alternative ways of being in the world, e.g. this coachee learned to delegate as one who wants to mentor others and is informed by stories of those who served him.

Growth is liminal

Coachees use *emplotment strategies* (Hermans & Kempen, 1993; Mattingly, 1994) to make sense of and choices about their experience as a means to define their identity, community, values, etc. These strategies operate largely at nonconscious and somatic levels, but they can be made conscious and malleable through coaching. Therefore, narrative coaches track the ways in which coachees organize their stories, e.g. which events are included, which themes they organize around, which characters are portrayed as significant, and which voices are privileged in the telling (Botella & Herrero, 2000). It is particularly useful to listen for what is missing – the gaps and, the thresholds (Drake, 2007) – where coachee's typical emplotment strategies have broken down or are no longer working. It is in these liminal, in-between spaces where growth most often occurs.

This is often the case because people form stories in response to disruptions in the canonical state of their world. Their goal in telling stories is to resolve the discrepancies between what they expected and what actually happened – what Bruner (1990) called 'breaches of the commonplace' – and to integrate the resulting disorder and return the situation back to 'normal'. However, a frequent outcome of effective coaching is the creation of a new 'normal' for clients. For example a workshop participant started with a story about how his firm poorly handled the departure of a close colleague. 'It was not supposed to be this way' in his view. Drawing on a phrase he had used, I asked him if this was ultimately about a direct challenge to his values. In agreeing, he recognized that it had raised doubts about his decision to seek partnership. He seemed torn between wanting to return to his 'normal' story about the firm in order to ease his disquiet and recognizing that his role as a new leader in the firm would require new stories about himself, about leadership, and about the firm.

Discourse is powerful

Narrative coaches help coachees examine their assumptions about reality through a deep engagement with their stories. In the process, their preconscious schemas and conceptual frames – the *macronarratives* (Angus, Levitt, & Hardtke, 1999) that shape how they live

their lives – come to light. This is important because experiences that are not consistent with coachees' preferred self-stories are not deemed significant and are often invisible (White, 1988). If coachees are to adopt new behaviours or attain new results, they must embody an identity and discourse from which to do so and from which the desired behaviours naturally arise. If they are to sustain this new identity, they need to regularly enact these new behaviours – and the stories that go with them. Working with coachees' stories helps them lift the internalized restraints that keep them from noticing the critical exceptions to their current self-descriptions that could be used to scaffold a new way of being in the world.

Therefore, a key task is to introduce to coachees the distinction between their traditionally *available narratives* and their latent *potential stories* (Drake, 2007). Available narratives are drawn from the vocabulary and grammar, plot lines and historical conventions, beliefs and norms of their cultural systems, and go on to inform the stories that coachees construct to understand their experiences and live their lives (Freedman & Combs, 1996). As people begin to recognize the limitations inherent in their available narratives, they can create more distance from these narratives, see them more clearly, and surface other 'selves'. As alternative stories become available, other 'sympathetic' and previously neglected aspects of the person's experience (and the related discourse) can be expressed (White & Epston, 1990) and embodied. Narrative coaching enables people to reframe and reposition themselves relative to their available narratives and to bring more of their potential stories to life.

Re-storying is possible

'Re-storying' is the process of creating a new alignment between one's identity, stories, and behaviours in order to *be* and to behave in new ways. It involves raising coachees' awareness of their current narrative patterns (and the sources and consequences) through working with the narrative material that emerges in the sessions as openings for new possibilities – new stories waiting to be midwived. In order for these kinds of shifts to occur, coachees first need to loosen their *narrative grip* on the past, present, and/or future (Boscolo & Bertrando, 1992) to create the space for new stories about themselves and others. In order to do so, narrative coaches often use experiential and imaginal activities to help coachees break the ossified bonds that have historically held them in the same stories.

Narrative coaches do this by helping coachees discern what they are trying to accomplish with the stories they currently tell (and for whom). In doing so, they come to terms with their hopes and fears as well as their habitual narrative genres and roles, i.e., victim or hero. As McKee (1997) asks, 'What does the coachee want that, if you gave it to her, would stop the story?' 'What value is at stake in her life at this moment?' The answer, the object of their desire, is often found where people must face their greatest fear or challenge, answer their most essential question, or make their hardest choice. However, as we often see in coaching, their 'holy grail' may not be the one they were originally seeking. For example I was asked to coach a key contributor in a manufacturing company to help her address some critical relational and performance issues. Her initial stories were of anger at her employer and her colleagues. However, through

exploring her story more fully she was able to reframe the issue as one in which she felt her professional passions and values had been compromised as the company had grown significantly. What she wanted ultimately was the chance to leave with dignity and the courage to return to the work she loved. In the end, she left the organization, moved to a new city and found a new job where she could thrive again – and the organizational players gained as well in releasing her and reflecting on how much the culture had indeed changed over the years.

THE ROLE OF THE NARRATIVE COACH AND THE RELATIONSHIP

[One's] role is correspondingly delicate. It may still not be, though, 'to change [their] story, for this is to deny it; it is, rather, to expand and deepen the story, thus releasing the energy bound within it.' (Houston, 1987: 99)

A narrative approach emphasizes real-time attention to facets of coachees' experience and narration in seeking points of leverage to support coachees' development, e.g. stories about eating dinner, empty moving boxes, a childhood mentor, and a dream of riding a boat down the river) that serve as portals to larger themes. For example the above stories led to the following, respectively: major lifestyle changes and early retirement; acknowledgment of anticipatory grief for an ill wife; a platform to celebrate and extend a new direction in business; and breaking a long-held pattern in work relationships and a new job. This approach requires a shift from thinking about a story as a fixed commodity transmitted from one person to another to thinking about a story as a co-created dynamic between the coachee and the coach. A key role for the coach is to create the container in which these processes become possible.

In order to do so, narrative coaches provide both an interpersonal structure, e.g. a safe space in which to tell the whole story and a narrative structure, for example using Bruner's (1990) notions of *landscapes of action* and *landscapes of consciousness*, to help coachees fully engage and explore their stories. Otherwise, coachees' stories devolve into mere chronicles and the process degrades into an abstract analysis – neither of which is productive in coaching. While recognizing this human need for a sense of order and a plot to live by (Hillman, 1983), it is also important that these structures remain in the background as a source for potential questions, rather than in the foreground as expectations to which coachees and their stories must conform.

As a result, narrative coaches take a *decentred* position and role in coaching conversations and remain cognizant of the balance of power. In doing so, they honour the knowledge of coachees about their lives and their primary status as authors of their lives (White, 2000). A narrative coach is generally off to the side somewhat from the coachee, such that they make room for the narrative work to occur in the field as it emerges between them. It also provides a visual cue for the coach in remembering to attend to the stories along with the person telling them. In my practice, I often make extensive use of my hands to *hold* and work with this space, e.g. holding up two story elements, one in each hand so to speak, and drawing the coachee's attention to what might connect them in the middle. A light yet disciplined touch is required by coaches to remain in a decentred position and fully trust the process rather than moving to the centre and trying to be 'helpful' through changing their coachees' stories.

A critical discipline therefore is for coaches to stay as much as possible in *storytime* and *storyspace* as they unfold in working with coachees and the narrative material. The focus here is on the story as it is being told in the here and now. In doing so, coaches continually bring coachees back into their present experience in order to connect the proverbial ‘dots’ and provide a more solid basis for change. For example, stories about the past and future are explored through such questions as, ‘When have you been here before?’ and ‘When might you be here again?’, the answers are brought back into the moment by asking such questions as, ‘What are you thinking/feeling about X right now?’

In an earlier work (Drake, 2008) based on the well-known opening for children’s fables, three dimensions of working in the present with coachees were identified. *Once upon a time* is about helping coachees be fully present as the narrator while creating a trusting space in which to do so. *Twice upon a time* is about advocating for the full story to emerge so that as much of the narrative material is available for the conversation. *Thrice upon a time* is about the field that is created in a coaching conversation between the coach, the coachee, and the narrative process where the coachee can reframe or rearrange the narrative material in order to gain a new perspective, sense of self, or options for action. These three dimensions reflect the interest in identity, narrative and behaviour, respectively, in coaching. These three dimensions are reflected in one of the classic narrative coaching processes, as can be seen in the following:

- (1) an issue or goal is presented
- (2) an invitation is made to tell the story about it, and other related elements or stories are elicited
- (3) any themes or patterns are tracked
- (4) a guiding image or metaphor is identified that seems to be at the heart of the issue
- (5) this image is worked within the conversational ‘field’
- (6) a resolution occurs – often in ways that transcend the original polarity or issue.

An example can be seen in this coaching interaction: (1) Presenting issue: ‘We just moved’; (2) Stories: Description of the move; (3) Themes: Smaller space, giving away; (4) Guiding image: Boxes in the kitchen; (5) Image in the *field*: Unpacking the boxes; and (6) Threshold and resolution: Recognition of anticipatory grief about the implications of the reason for the move.

PRIMARY GOALS AND TASKS

Listening as a method for change

A key goal in narrative coaching is to search for elements in a coachee’s stories that are ‘amenable to challenge, redefinition, or alternative interpretation so that a new definition of the problem can emerge’ (Coulehan, Friedlander, & Heatherington, 1998: 18). One of the core skills in doing so is deep and generative listening based in a commitment to presence, mindfulness, and attention. In addition to working with the words of their coachees’ stories, narrative coaches are fully present to the coachee as the narrator, remain mindful of their own impact on the story formation, and pay close attention to the nuances of what is said (and not said) in

their interchanges. They listen in some unique ways, particularly to the nonverbal and nonrational elements of their coaching conversations.

Listening this way reaches coachees at multiple levels as a means to connect to the whole person, open up a wider range of material for coaching, and enrich the narrative field on the coachees' behalf. In this sense, listening can be seen as a 360° experience and not a dyadic transaction. A key role for coaches then is to 'invite people to see their stories from different perspectives, to notice how they are constructed (or even that they are constructed), to note their limits and influences, and to discover other possibilities' (Freedman & Combs, 1996). It is about helping coachees notice the differences between the stories they are telling and the stories they are living as well as to identify narrative 'data' from their lives that will support an alternate view of who they are and how they want to be in the world. For example I invited a coachee who looked longingly off into space after stating his issue to verbalize the untold story that was playing in his mind — and to use the feelings of grief which emerged to identify the next steps he needed to take.

The *Narrative Diamond*TM model (Drake, 2007) is used to teach this work and deepen the practice of listening. The underlying presumption is that the characters, objects, and events that appear in our stories are systematically related to the other figures in ways that are important to explore. As such, coaches listen carefully for what is said, not said, wants to be said, and is being said differently in order to gain a deeper understanding of these relationships. This aligns with the notion of *dialogical space*, wherein 'new relationships are established between existing story parts or new elements are introduced' (Hermans, 2004: 175) and narrative researchers who study how people 'locate characters in their stories in relation to one another and in relation to themselves' (Riessman, 2002) and how they position and 'reposition these characters ... within a constantly moving interpersonal field' (Anderson, 2004: 317).

Working with coachees' stories and the characters in them, beyond their ego's reach, is powerful because it gives them access to aspects of themselves which are often hidden yet in motion in their psyche. This is important because development generally occurs for coachees outside their habitual plot lines and their psyche's defences. Narrative coaches support this process through listening in a way that is active yet nondirective, nonattached yet generative. A key skill in this regard is to listen simultaneously at multiple levels within the field and to the stories themselves. In this way, narrative coaches are truly 'active' in their listening as they are, paradoxically, both fully engaged and wholly nonattached in helping their coachees to discover and step into a new story of and with their life.

COMPARISONS AND APPLICATIONS

Narrative coaching is based in a unique philosophical stance and a distinct set of methodologies. At the same time, it shares commonalities with other theories and approaches to coaching: (1) the inter-personal nature of the coaching process and the role of conflict as found in the psychodynamic approach; (2) the genuine empathetic presence and commitment to self-actualization and self-determination as found in the person-centred approach; (3) the emphasis

on in-the-moment awareness and experimental actions, coachees' language, and expectations of self-responsibility as found in the gestalt approach; (4) an interest in phenomenological methods, unlocking sedimentation, and issues of what IS as found in the existential approach; (5) the values around interconnectedness and spirituality as found in the transpersonal approach; and (6) the willingness to work across all domains of experience, e.g. language, emotions, and physiology, as found in the ontological approach.

Narrative coaching at work

Developmental coaching: A narrative approach helps coachees draw new connections between their personal stories and the collective stories in which they are embedded. A narrative approach can be particularly useful in working with coachees at turning points in how they want to present themselves and/or be seen by others. For example a coachee who had been promoted to VP of Engineering traced his career trajectory in order to make better sense of the difficulties he was experiencing in his new role. We identified the three stages of his career as 'expert, manager and leader', and we explored his stories about himself in each one and the stories others had of him as he advanced. In comparing these stories, he recognized that, in large part, he still saw himself and acted from an old role – particularly as the 'expert' – and he needed to let go in order to step more fully into his new role.

Team coaching: Teams are often caught between organizational demands, client expectations, and personal agendas as they seek to fulfil their mission. A narrative approach to working with teams helps them to surface and sort through their individual and collective stories as a way to address conflict, align their purpose, or shift their patterns of engagement. For example in taking a narrative approach in coaching the IT teams in a health care organization to provide better customer service, they were invited to collectively construct a model of the flow of a key system, visit several sites to see their technology in action, and gather user stories from their stakeholder groups. The essence of shifts that resulted were captured by one participant who reframed his story from 'I want to be left alone to build servers' to 'people depend on me in order to serve our patients'.

Manager as coach: A narrative approach can be used to help managers and leaders understand what is meaningful to them, relinquish the self-imposed burden to have all the answers, and find a healthy balance between being appreciative in growing people and assertive in managing performance. In my work with a global professional services firm, leaders and coaching champions were invited to share stories of their 'experiments' in bringing coaching to bear in new ways in meeting the needs of their teams. As these stories have spread, there have been noticeable shifts in the openness to learning, engagement with coaching, clarity around roles in coaching, and the overall vibe in many of the teams. Coaching is no longer seen primarily as the formal, obligatory, and generally unidirectional sessions dutifully done a few times a year, but rather as the natural, invitational and mutual way all conversations are framed and all business gets done.

EVALUATION

A key focus over the past seven years has been the theory building and process development that have been essential in creating the philosophical foundations and applications for this method. Much of the research that has informed narrative coaching to date has been drawn from efforts in related fields such as narrative psychology and narrative medicine. Narrative approaches are ideal for helping at key turning points when they are in between stories. They can also be used to underpin behaviour change and goal achievement (Hart, 1995) by making connections between internal schemas and external actions and between personal stories and cultural narratives. Narrative coaching seems to work best with coachees who have (1) a comfort with silence and self-reflection; (2) a willingness to work at emotional, metaphorical, and nonrational levels; (3) an astute awareness of and ability to articulate their experience; and (4) the necessary ego strength to be able to self-disclose through their stories.

Obviously, this approach is more challenging if any of the above four conditions are not present in the coach and/or coachee. Also, while narrative approaches often lead to important insights as a platform and frame for change, they are philosophically non-directive and they may need to be augmented with other methods when coaching requires a more directive or tactical approach. Another concern stems from the ties to narrative therapy and its emphasis on issues of power, oppression, and justice. This can be a challenge for narrative coaches who are sensitized to these issues but may be engaged with coaches or organizations who are not. Lastly, given the social and cultural basis for stories, both as identity and discourse, this approach to coaching must be done with a high level of awareness in order to remain as 'clean' and clear as possible in the process.

CONCLUSION

The roots of narrative approaches to coaching can be seen as a movement from *text* to *context* to *subtext*, a progression that was accelerated by the rise of postmodernism and the shift from 'stories-as-objects' to 'stories-in-context' (Boje, 1998). It is a process that focuses on narrative identity, growth at the thresholds, the power of discourse, and the possibilities for new stories. It is based in a commitment by narrative coaches to (1) be mindful and compassionate; (2) listen deeply and respectfully; and (3) engage courageously and fluidly with the stories in the conversational field.

In *thinking narratively* (Drake, 2007) in a coaching conversation, coaches place more emphasis on generating experiences and less on rushing to interpretation, meaning, or action. It does not matter which stories coachees choose to share first; narrative coaches trust that coachees will begin at the level at which they are ready and the critical themes will be forthcoming. Therefore, the aim is to create a rich narrative field, notice what appears, remain connected even

in silence, actively engage with the narrative material as it emerges, and trust that any one story or set of stories is a portal into the larger issues at play for coachees in reaching their ‘object of desire’. At the same time, narrative-based coaches know that any story told in a coaching session, even if it has served as a transformational vehicle in that setting, must survive the ‘retellings’ if coachees are to sustain the changes they have begun.

As such, the narrative coach helps coachees to connect their personal stories with the social contexts from which they came and to which they will return in new ways – both in the session itself and in crafting experiments based on their work together. A narrative approach to coaching is a powerful method for helping coachees to (1) become more aware of their own stories, (2) recognize how these stories shape their identity and behaviour at both conscious and unconscious levels, (3) understand that these stories are personally and socially constructed, and (4) be more authorial in aligning their stories with identities and actions that would enable them to authentically embody a new way of being in the world. Overall, it is a present-focused, non-directive and experiential approach more than one that is future-focused, action-oriented and goal-driven. Ultimately, people can only see as far as their stories will take them, and they can only act as far as their stories will back them.

FURTHER READING

- Freedman, J., & Combs, G. (1996). *Narrative therapy: The social construction of preferred realities*. New York: Norton and Co. (This excellent introduction to narrative therapy features a good blend of theoretical and practice considerations. As a way to understand its similarities and differences relative to a narrative approach to coaching.)
- McKee, R. (1997). *Story: Substance, structure, style and the principles of screenwriting*. New York: HarperCollins. (The master when it comes to understanding screenwriting; he brings together a classic literary knowledge with a sound knowledge of contemporary culture in providing a deep resource on narrative structure.)
- Schank, R.A. (1990). *Tell me a story: A new look at real and artificial memory*. New York: Charles Scribner's Sons. (Reading this book was pivotal for me as I studied how to create better transfer of learning and more sustainable change in developing managers and leaders. An educator, he writes with a sound grasp of the research on schemas and other core concepts from cognitive science, but does so from a starting point of the mind as a storyteller.)

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